should surface. The procedures were not part of peacetime US naval activity. They involved use of MK 64 practice depth charges by ASW helicopters. ‘When our forces come upon an unidentified submarine,’ McNamara explained, ‘we will ask it to come to the surface for inspection by transmitting the following signals, using a depth charge of this type and also using certain sonar signals which they may not able be to accept and interpret. Therefore, it is the depth charge that is the warning notice and the instruction to surface.’[91]

Contrary to Admiral Anderson’s assertions about the navy’s experience with blockades, the SSIP procedures were improvised. McNamara told ExComm that it was a new procedure, which he had asked the navy to establish the previous day, 23 October. It was clearly crucial that the captains of the submarines understood the purpose of using practice depth charges. Alexis Johnson, Under-Secretary State of State, explained that the identification procedures had been communicated to the US Embassy in Moscow the previous evening, for delivery to the Soviet authorities (though Johnson had yet to receive confirmation the Soviet authorities had received them). Subsequently, the procedures were publicly announced in a Notice to Mariners on 25 October.

There was a brief exchange with McNamara about communication in which he said that he was ‘sure that [the details of the procedures] got to the Soviet Union [and] to the submarine’. Why he could be sure the message sent to the Soviet Foreign Ministry had reached Soviet submarines in the Caribbean overnight is anybody’s guess. What is striking is that there were no ‘probing questions’ on this potentially critical issue.

If the Soviet submariners did not know the depth charges were a signalling device and thought they were under attack, they would presumably have believed they were at war. The President and his advisers uncritically accepted McNamara’s assumptions and assertions that ad hoc procedures would be immediately conveyed to the submarine captains. The implications of this eventuality for crisis management were simply not discussed in ExComm.

Perhaps most extraordinary was McNamara’s belief that a Soviet submarine captain would surface his boat ‘for inspection’ in response to a